Chatterjee, formerly the vice chancellor of the university. Chatterjee doesn't volunteer the information, but once I ask, she tells me that 60 percent of her three thousand undergraduates are women, many of whom do better than the men at their studies. This echoes what the vice chancellor at Madras told me. In fact, in recent years, women have excelled in India's national civil service examinations. From 2010 through 2012, and from 2014 through 2016, the top scorers among five hundred thousand applicants in the exam were women, sometimes taking the top four slots, as in 2014. In 2013, women made up half of the top twenty-five scorers, while in 2017, eight of the top twenty-five were women.[10]

Walking around several university campuses, I see far more young women than men studying in corridors or talking in classrooms. This female educational excellence also spills down to secondary education, where 87 percent of graduating high school girls passed their Class 12 (senior year) exams in 2012, compared to just 78 percent of boys.[11] As in the United States, women are increasingly the top grade earners on college campuses and in high schools. One would expect that they would thus be a national force in business, professional education, government, and the like. Yet such statistics are misleading, for in the country as a whole fewer than half of India's women are literate, leaving hundreds of millions far worse off than Sita and her college-educated friends.

If Sita is any guide, the talents of many of the twelve million women enrolled in undergraduate programs may not be put to full use once they've graduated, which is a condition facing most women throughout the Indo-Pacific region. Generalization is a fool's errand in India, with its billion diverse people, but during my discussion with Sita, she gave no indication that her situation was markedly different from her friends or workmates. When I ask a professor at the University of Calcutta what his female graduate students will do after their studies, he shrugs his shoulders. Some will get research and administrative jobs, he indicates, but marriage will end the careers and aspirations of many of India's young women. I wonder if the relative lack of young